Hustle Hive CIC – Whistleblowing Policy

Item	Detail
Organisation	Hustle Hive CIC, company no. 16691281
Policy lead	Kieron Davis, Director
Version	2.0 (replaces HHL-P12, July 2026)
Effective from	October 2026
Next review	September 2027, or sooner if the law or our structure changes

1. Purpose

Hustle Hive CIC is committed to honesty, openness and keeping children and young people safe. We want anyone who works with us to feel able to speak up if they think something is wrong, knowing they will be listened to and will not be treated unfairly for doing so.

This policy explains how to raise a concern, what will happen and how you are protected. It reflects the Public Interest Disclosure Act 1998, part of the Employment Rights Act 1996, and the expectations in *Keeping Children Safe in Education*.

2. Who this policy applies to

This policy applies to directors, employees, sessional and freelance staff, volunteers, students on placement, agency workers and contractors. Parents, carers and learners who have a concern should speak to any member of staff or contact a Director.

3. What you can raise

You can raise any concern that you reasonably believe shows wrongdoing that is in the public interest, whether it has happened, is happening or is likely to happen. Examples include:

- a failure to keep children or vulnerable adults safe, or poor or unsafe safeguarding practice;
- a criminal offence;
- a risk to anyone's health and safety;
- fraud, financial irregularity or misuse of grant funding or company money;
- a breach of a legal duty, including data protection;
- discrimination; and
- an attempt to cover up any of the above.

You do not need proof. You only need a reasonable belief that something is wrong.

4. What this policy does not cover

- **Allegations that an adult has harmed a child.** These must be reported straight away under section 9 of our Safeguarding and Child Protection Policy, which includes going to the Local Authority Designated Officer (LADO). If a child is in immediate danger, call 999.
- **Concerns about a specific child's welfare.** These go to the Designated Safeguarding Lead under our Safeguarding policy.
- **Personal complaints about your own job,** such as pay, workload or how you have been treated. Raise these with a Director as a grievance.

5. How to raise a concern

Raise your concern as early as you can, in person, by phone or in writing. Say what has happened, when, who was involved and why you are worried. Your concern goes to:

If your concern is about	Tell
Anything not involving a Director	Gavin Copland or Kieron Davis
Gavin Copland	Kieron Davis (07395 828429, kieron@hustlehive.co.uk)
Kieron Davis	Gavin Copland (07593 975681, gavin@hustlehive.co.uk)

If your concern is about	Tell
Both Directors, or if you feel unable to raise it internally	An outside organisation (see section 8)

You can bring a colleague or trade union representative to any meeting about your concern.

6. What happens next

1. **Acknowledgement.** We acknowledge your concern within 5 working days.
2. **Assessment.** The Director who receives it decides how to look into it. If the concern involves both Directors, we refer it to the appropriate outside organisation in section 8. If it involves a risk to a child, they follow our Safeguarding policy straight away.
3. **Investigation.** The concern is investigated fairly and in proportion. Where needed, we involve or refer to outside bodies such as the LADO, children's services, the police, the Health and Safety Executive or the Regulator of Community Interest Companies, or our funders.
4. **Feedback.** We aim to tell you the outcome within 20 working days, or explain why it will take longer. We may not be able to share every detail, for example to protect other people's confidentiality.
5. **Record.** We keep a confidential record of the concern, the action taken and the outcome.

If you are not happy with how your concern has been handled, raise it with the other Director or with an outside organisation.

7. Confidentiality and protection

- **Confidentiality.** We will keep your identity confidential if you ask us to, unless the law requires us to share it. If it becomes impossible to investigate without revealing your identity, we will discuss this with you first.
- **Anonymous concerns.** You can raise a concern anonymously. We will look into it as far as we can, but it may be harder to investigate or give you feedback.
- **No victimisation.** No one will be disciplined, dismissed, bullied or treated unfairly for raising a genuine concern, even if it turns out to be mistaken. Anyone who victimises a whistleblower will face disciplinary action.
- **False concerns.** Deliberately making a false or malicious report may lead to disciplinary action.

8. Raising concerns outside Hustle Hive CIC

We hope you will feel able to raise concerns with us first. If you do not, or you are unhappy with our response, you can contact:

Organisation	For	Contact
NSPCC Whistleblowing Advice Line	Concerns about how children are being safeguarded	0800 028 0285, help@nspcc.org.uk
Darlington Designated Officer (LADO)	Concerns that an adult working with children may pose a risk	01325 405319, designatedofficer@darlington.gov.uk
Darlington Children's Initial Advice Team	Concerns about a child's safety	01325 406252
Health and Safety Executive	Health and safety risks	hse.gov.uk
Information Commissioner's Office	Data protection breaches	ico.org.uk
Office of the Regulator of Community Interest Companies	Concerns about how the CIC is run	gov.uk
Protect (independent whistleblowing charity)	Free, confidential advice on how to raise a concern	protect-advice.org.uk

The law also protects disclosures made to "prescribed persons". The full list is on GOV.UK. In most cases you will not be protected if you go to the media first, so please seek advice before doing so.

9. Responsibilities and review

The Directors are responsible for this policy, and Kieron Davis leads on it. All staff and volunteers are told about it during induction. The Directors review all whistleblowing concerns once a year to check the policy is working, and review the policy every year.

Related policies

Read this policy alongside our Safeguarding and Child Protection, Safer Recruitment, Health & Safety and Data Protection policies, and our staff code of conduct.

Approval and signatures

This policy has been approved by the Board of Directors of Hustle Hive CIC.

Name	Position	Signature	Date
Gavin Copland	Director		
Kieron Davis	Director		
Carey Viala	Director		
Sarah Smith	Director		